

INDIVIDUAL DIFFERENCES, MENTAL ABILITY, AND PERSONALITY

Learning Objectives:

- ✓ Understand the individual differences
- ✓ Learn and grasp how people are different from one another

Introduction

Workers in most factories produce standardized materials that will make the final product easier to manufacture. If this process of handling materials can be applied to the management of people, achieving the objectives of the organization will be a much easier task. This cannot happen because of the big difference between materials and people.

Materials do not complain even if they are cut into standardized pieces, or stored in a warehouse. People cannot be subjected to such treatment if they are to be useful to the organization.

If one contemplates on the difficulty of the job of the person who has to relate with people, he will conclude that the job is more complicated. This is because people are different from one another and there is no single way to relate with them.

This chapter is an attempt to provide some important clues on individual differences, mental ability and personality.

INDIVIDUAL DIFFERENCES

Individual differences refer to the variation in how people respond to the same situation based on personal characteristics.' The idea is that each person is different from all others and that these differences are usually substantial rather than meaningless.

For instance, when management introduced the playing of soft music at the workplace, employee A was affected positively and he was able to perform his duties more efficiently. At the end of the first day the music was introduced, his output increased from 20 to 25 finished items. Employee B, however, was distracted, and his output decreased from 21 to 18 finished units. Employee C appreciates the music, but he feels that his output will increase by 25 percent if the music is a little louder and more upbeat.

Consequences of Individual Differences

Individual differences become serious concerns when people are situated in the workplace . Those concerned with managing people or simply those that want to relate well with people must be aware that there are consequences arising out of differences between people. These pertain to the following:

1. people differ in productivity;
2. people differ in the quality of their work
3. people react differently to empowerment;
4. people react differently to any style of leadership;
5. people differ in terms of need for contact with other people;
6. people differ in terms of commitment to the organization; and

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7. people differ in terms of level of self-esteem.

Productivity refers to the rate of output per worker. It differs from person to person. If the rate of output in a sales office is measured in terms of number of units sold by each salesman, it cannot be expected that everyone will sell the same number of units for a given period. This may be attributed to individual differences among the salesmen like experience, age, education, and the like.

Because people are different from each other, it is not surprising that the quality of their work will also be different. Some individuals will not be contented in making products of mediocre quality, while others will just strive to produce outputs that barely passed standard requirements.

Empowerment means giving someone the power to do something. For instance, an individual may be empowered to sign purchased contracts and with it the authority to determine what supplies and materials are needed to be purchase. Some person or feel happy if he is provided with such responsibility, others will feel uncomfortable and will prefer to just follow orders.

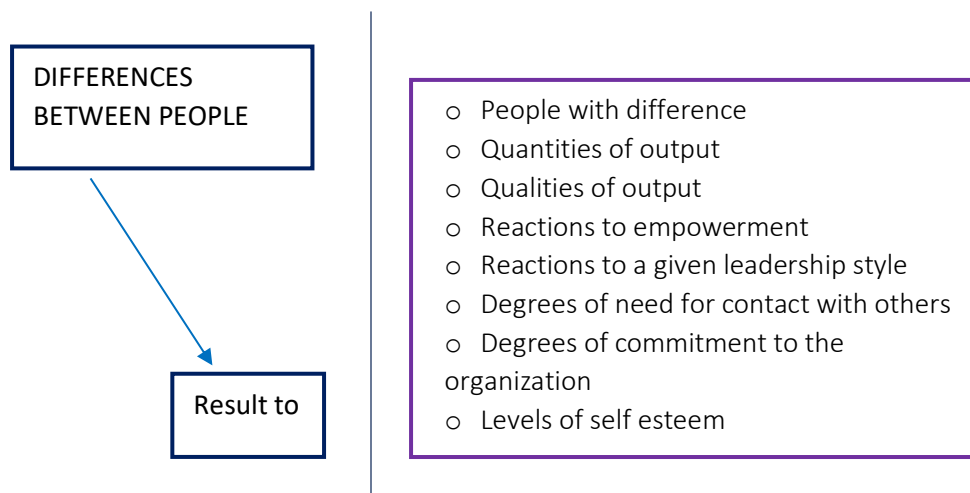


Figure 2
The consequences of differences between people

If all subordinates in a given unit will respond well to a single style of leadership, managing them or simply relating with them would be a much easier task. But this is not so, as some people will prefer a leader with a democratic style, while some will need close supervision from their superiors. These differences make it necessary for a leader to use different leadership styles even in a small unit.

Regarding the need for social contact, people are also different from one another. Some will need more contact, while others can work alone the whole day. Other people cannot be productive unless they meet people as they work. The salesman's job, for instance, is well fitted for those in need of frequent interactions with other people. In contrast, there are those who can perform jobs in research laboratories where contact with others is minimal.

Commitment to the organization varies among individuals. Some are so committed and loyal to the organization that they work the whole day without noticing that they are putting in more than the required

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working hours. Those who are highly committed to the organization tend to produce high quality output, while those who are less committed are less concerned about output and attendance.

People also differ in terms of self - esteem. Those with low self- esteem tend to be less productive. They also avoid accepting more responsibilities. They do so for various reasons, one of which is that they may think that their abilities do not match the requirements job. The opposite happens when people have high regard of themselves. Many great inventions, literary work, and discoveries were made by people with high self-esteem.

WHAT MAKES PEOPLE DIFFERENT FROM EACH OTHER

People are different from each other because they are different in terms of the following:

1. demographics;
2. aptitude and ability, and
3. personality.

Demographic Diversity

Performance in the workplace and the behavior of workers are sometimes affected by the differences between the demographic characteristics of individual workers.

The sources of demographic diversity include the following:

1. gender;
2. generational differences and age, and
3. culture.

Gender Differences.

The differences in the perception of male and female roles are referred to as gender differences. Research findings indicate that there are very few differences between men and women that affect job performance. Specifically, men and women are not different along the following concerns:

1. problem solving abilities;
2. analytical skills;
3. competitive drive
4. motivation;
5. learning ability; and
6. sociability

Generational and Age-Based Differences.

A worker that belongs to a certain generation may behave differently from a worker who belongs to another. This difference is called generational difference. An example may be derived from the changes in values over generations. For instance, in a generation that values loyalty, it will not be difficult to find workers who have stayed in their respective companies for long periods. The opposite may be expected from a generation that values something else.

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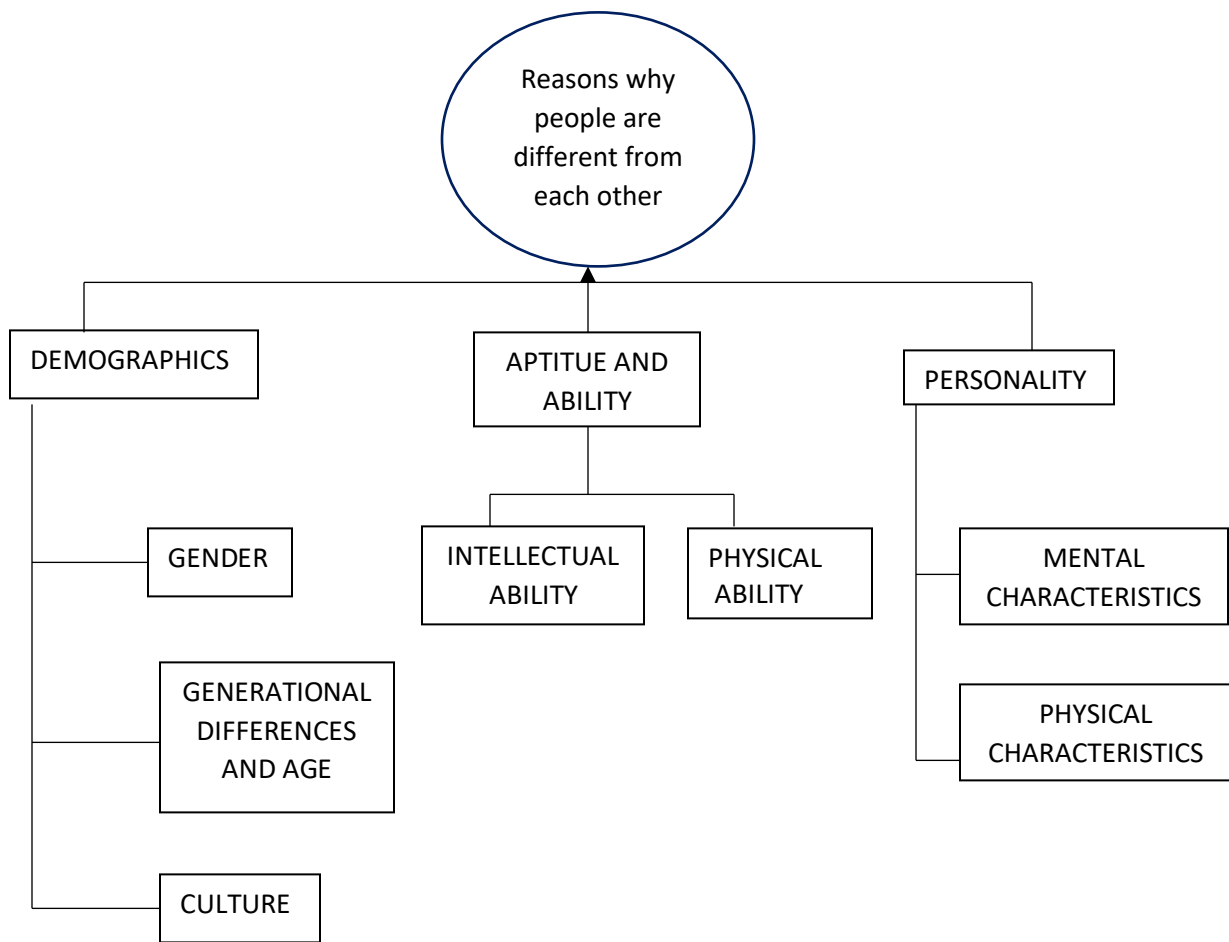


FIGURE 3
What makes people different from each other

Differences in the ages of workers also bring about expectations of differences in the behavior of workers. Most often, age is associated with experience, so we take it as a matter of course when a 61-year-old person says that he has 40 years of teaching experience, or when employee a 26-year-old has a 5-year teaching experience. This is not always true, however, because there are instances when people over 60 years old have less than 10 years of teaching experience. In general, however, we consider age and experiences as related.

Culture. Differences in job performance and behavior sometimes caused by differences in culture. If, for instance, a Filipino employee is confronted by a superior for a perceived error committed by the employee at the workplace, it is not surprising if the employee keeps quiet even if he believes he is not at fault. It may take some effort for someone to make him respond. This is so because Filipinos consider it impolite and discourteous to talk back to superiors or elders. This behavior is common to Filipinos and we cannot expect people from other cultures to behave in the same manner.

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Culture refers to the learned and shared ways of thinking and acting among a group of people or society. This definition implies that culture has two dimensions. Specifically, these are classified as follows:

1. **Social culture** - which refers to the social environment of human-created beliefs, customs, knowledge, and practices that define conventional behavior in a society.
2. **Organizational culture** - is the set of values, beliefs, and norms that is shared among members of an organization.

Aptitude and Ability

People differ in terms of aptitude and ability and their behavior in the organization is affected.

Aptitude may be defined as the capacity of a person to learn or acquire skills. Ability refers to an individual's capacity to perform the various tasks in a job.

Aptitudes and abilities are very important considerations when people are considered for employment in an organization. The managers of business firms will be much concerned with the cost of training new employees before they become productive. Low aptitude and abilities would mean higher training costs.

A person's overall abilities are made up of two sets of factors: physical and mental.

Physical ability refers to the capacity of the individual to do tasks demanding stamina, dexterity, strength, and similar characteristics. Specifically, there are nine physical abilities needed to perform certain tasks. These are the following:

1. Dynamic strength - this is the ability to exert muscular force repeatedly or continuously over time.
2. Trunk strength - this is the ability to exert muscular strength using the trunk (particularly the abdominal muscles) muscles.
3. Static strength - this is the ability to exert force against external objects.
4. Explosive strength - this is the ability to expend a maximum of energy in one or a series of explosive acts.
5. Extent flexibility - this is the ability to move the trunk and back muscles as far as possible.
6. Dynamic flexibility - this is the ability to make rapid, repeated flexing movements.
7. Body coordination - this is the ability to coordinate the simultaneous actions of different parts of the body.
8. Balance - this is the ability to maintain equilibrium despite forces pulling off balance.
9. Stamina - this is the ability to continue maximum effort requiring prolonged effort over time.

Individuals will differ as to the extent by which they can perform any of the above-cited physical abilities.

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The intellectual or *mental ability* of a person (also referred to as intelligence) is one of the major sources of individual differences. Intellectual abilities refer to the capacity to do mental activities, such as thinking, reasoning, and problem solving.

Dimensions of Intellectual Ability. Intelligence is composed of four subparts which are as follows:

1. cognitive
2. social
3. emotional
4. cultural

Cognitive intelligence refers to the capacity of a person to acquire and apply knowledge including solving problems

Social intelligence refers to a person's ability to relate effectively with others.

Emotional intelligence refers to a person's qualities such as understanding one's own feelings, empathy for others, and the regulation of emotion to enhance living.

Cultural intelligence refers to an outsider's ability to interpret someone's unfamiliar and ambiguous behavior the same way that person's compatriot would

Intelligence Subparts and Individual Variations

The intelligence levels on the four subparts differ from person to person. For instance, an individual could get high ratings on two intelligence subparts, e.g., cognitive and social but low on emotional and cultural. Another person could be rated average on all four subparts, and the like.

In real life situation, it is not surprising to see an individual who scores below average in school examinations but gets elected as student council president. Or a student who gets excellent scores in written examinations but is hampered by shyness in meeting other people. Both persons have dissimilar strengths and weaknesses, and it can be expected that their behaviors will also be dissimilar even inside organizations.

The Triarchic Theory of Intelligence

An eminent researcher, Robert Sternberg, developed an approach to the study of intelligence, which is now known as the triarchic theory of intelligence. He maintains that there are three important parts of problems. intelligence, namely:

1. componential intelligence;
2. experiential intelligence; and
3. contextual intelligence.

People can be good at any or all of the three intelligence parts. *Componential intelligence*, also referred to as analytical intelligence, it involves components (or mental processes) used in thinking. This is the traditional

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type of intelligence needed for solving difficult problems with abstract reasoning. People who score high in componential intelligence perform well in most school subjects.

Experiential intelligence, also referred to as creative intelligence, is that type of intelligence that focuses on how people perform on tasks with which they have either little or no previous experience or else great experience. It is this type of intelligence that is required for imagination and combining things in novel ways.

Contextual intelligence, also known as practical intelligence, is a type of everyday intelligence or street smarts. It requires adapting to, selecting, and shaping our real-world environment.

Contextual intelligence incorporates the ideas of common sense, wisdom, and street smarts.

Multiple Intelligences

Another eminent researcher, Howard Gardner, developed a very useful means of understanding intelligence. It is referred to as the Theory of Multiple Intelligences. He proposes eight different components of intelligence which the individual possesses in varying degrees.

A brief description of the components is provided as follows:

1. *Linguistic*. People who possess this component of intelligence is sensitive to language, meanings, and the relations among words. Linguistic intelligence makes people able to communicate through language including reading, writing, and speaking. This is a distinct characteristic of novelist, poets, copywriter, scriptwriter, editors, magazine writers, public relations directors, and speech writers.
2. *Logical-Mathematical*. This intelligence component covers abstract thought, precision, counting, organization, and logical structure, enabling the individual to see relationship between objects and solve problems such as those in algebra and actuarial concerns. This is a characteristic of mathematicians, scientists, engineers, animal trackers, police investigators, and lawyers.
3. *Musical*. This intelligence component gives people the capacity to create and understand meanings made out of sounds and to enjoy different types of music. The person endowed with such intelligence component is sensitive to pitch, rhythm, timbre, and the emotional power and complex organization of music. This characteristic is found in performers, composers, conductors, musical audience, recording engineers, and makers of musical instruments.
4. *Spatial*. This intelligence component enables people to perceive and manipulate images in their brain and to re-create them from memory, such as in making graphic designs.

The person with spatial intelligence is blessed with abilities concerning keen observation, visual thinking, mental images, metaphor, essence of the whole, and gestalt.

This intelligence is found in architects, painters, sculptors, navigators, chess players, theoretical physicians, and battlefield commanders.

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5. *Bodily-kinesthetic*. This intelligence enables people to use their body and perceptual and motor systems in skilled ways, such as dancing, playing sports, and expressing emotion through facial expressions.

This is found in athletes, dancers, actors, inventors, mimers surgeons, karate teachers, and the mechanically gifted.

6. *Intrapersonal*. The person with this kind of intelligence has highly accurate understanding of himself or herself. He or she is sensitive to his or her values, purpose, feelings, and has developed sense of self. This is found in novelists, counselors, wise elders philosophers, gurus and persons with deep sense of self.
7. *Interpersonal*. This intelligence component makes possible for persons to recognize and make distinctions among the feelings, motives, and intentions of others, as in managing people and parenting children.

This is found in politicians, teachers, religious leaders counselors, salesmen, and managers.

8. *Naturalist*. A person with this intelligence possesses the ability to seek patterns in the external physical environment. As a result, the opportunity to enrich all the other seven intelligences is provided.

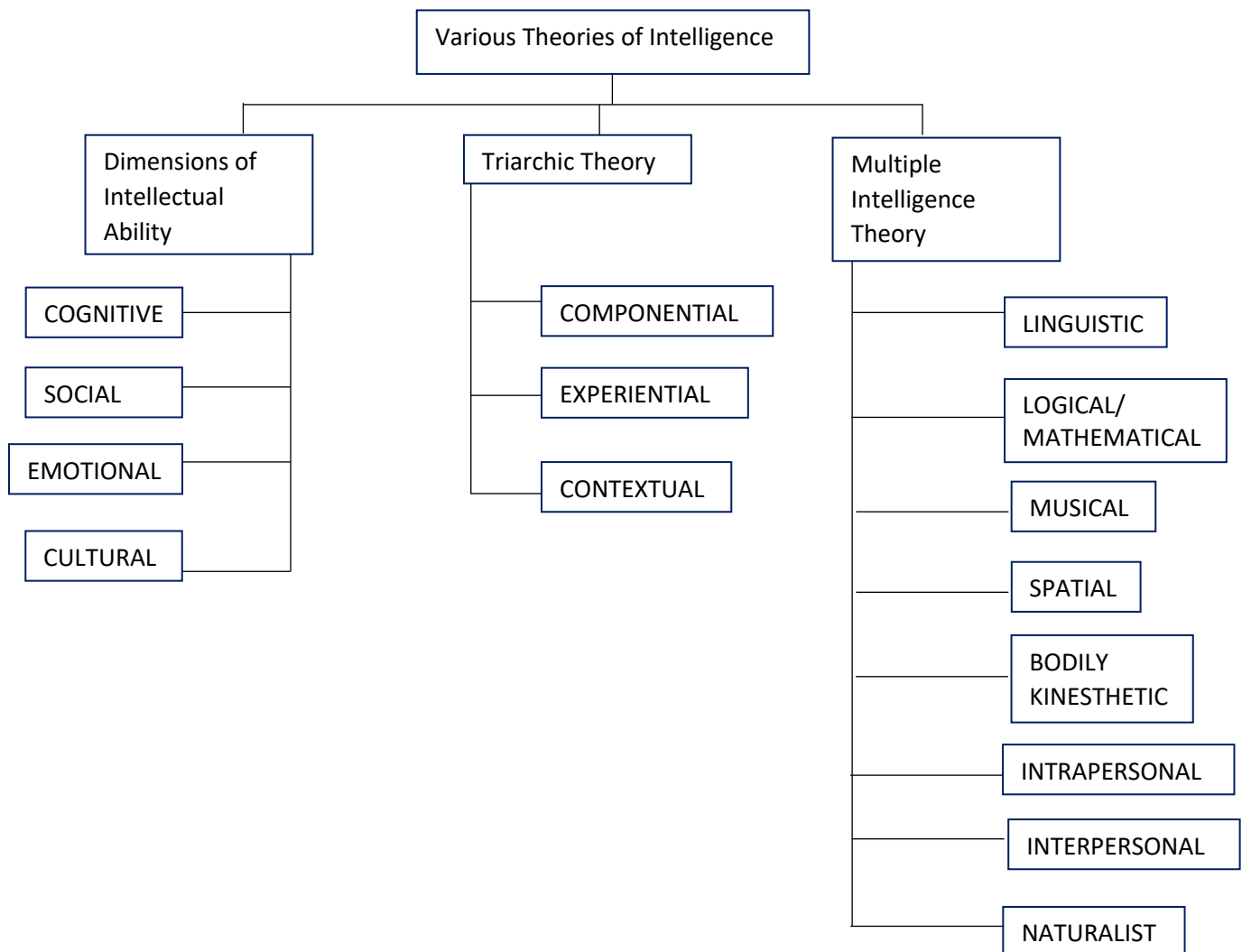


Figure 4

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Personality

One aspect that makes people different from one another is personality. The differences translate into different behaviors, including those in the workplaces.

Personality refers to the sum total of ways in which an individual reacts and interacts with others. The "ways" are the patterns of behavior that are consistent and enduring.

Determinants of Personality

The personality of an individual is a result of both hereditary and environmental factors. Heredity defines the limits by which environment can develop personality characteristics.

Hereditary factors are those factors that are determined at conception

These include the following:

1. physical stature
2. facial attractiveness
3. Gender
4. temperament
5. muscle composition and reflexes
6. energy level
7. biological rhythms

Environmental factors are those that exert pressures on the formation of an individual's personality. It includes the following:

1. Cultural factor - which refer to the established norms, attitudes, and values that are passed along from one generation to the next and creates consistency over time.
2. Social factor - which refer to those that reflect family life, religion and the many kinds of formal and informal groups in which the individual participates throughout his life.
3. Situational factors - which indicate that the individual will behave differently in different situations. For instance, a teenager will be less talkative when in the presence of strangers. He will be more relaxed, however, when he is among friends and relatives.

Personality Factors and Traits

There are certain factors that are considered in determining human personality. A person's personality traits could either be on the positive or negative side of the factors, and they will be in various degrees of development. It is not hard to think that two or more persons will have the same traits that are developed in different degrees. This alone provides sufficient indication that individuals are really different from one another.

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The traits are partially inherited and they will develop depending on the environment where the person is situated. For instance, an employee may have a natural tendency for risk taking like experimenting on entrepreneurial ventures. This tendency will have the opportunity to grow in an organization that encourages such activities.

The eight factors are briefly described below:

1. *Emotional stability*. This personality factor characterizes one as calm, self-confident, and secure. Its opposite is emotional instability characterized by nervousness, depression, and insecurity.

A person who possesses a high degree of emotional stability can be expected to withstand stress.

2. *Extraversion*. This is the personality factor describing someone who is sociable, gregarious, and assertive. The opposite is introversion, which describes a person who tends to be reserved, timid, and quiet
3. *Openness to experience*. This is a personality factor describing a person who is imaginative, cultured, curious, original, broad-minded, intelligent, and artistically sensitive. The opposite is the person who is conventional and finds comfort in the familiar.
4. *Agreeableness*. This factor refers to the person's interpersonal orientation. An agreeable person is cooperative, warm, and trusting. The person who is not agreeable is cold, disagreeable, and antagonistic.
5. *Conscientiousness*. This factor refers to a person's reliability. Those with a high degree of conscientiousness are responsible, organized, dependable, and persistent. Those with a low degree of conscientiousness are easily distracted, disorganized, and unreliable.
6. *Self-monitoring behavior*. This reflects a person's ability to adjust his or her behavior to external, situational or environmental factors. High self monitors are pragmatic and are capable of putting on different faces for different audiences. Low self-monitors find it hard to act or behave as the situation requires.
7. Risk taking and thrill seeking. These refers to the person's willingness to take risk and pursue thrills that sometimes are required in the workplaces. Some jobs like those of movie stunts are dangerous and will require a high degree of risk taking and thrill-seeking sense.
8. Optimism. This refers to the tendency to experience positive emotional states and to typically believe that positive outcomes will be forthcoming from most activities. This is the opposite of pessimism which is the tendency to experience negative emotional states and to typically believe that negative outcomes will be forthcoming from most activities.

EMOTIONAL INTELLIGENCE

Positive personality factors in combination with practical intelligence can work wonders for the person and for the most part will be limited only by how far his or her emotions will allow. This provides clue on the importance of managing one's emotions especially in the workplaces. This implies that success in any endeavor

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requires a certain degree of emotional intelligence. The concept of emotional intelligence or emotional quotient (EQ) was introduced by Daniel Goleman. EQ refers to the ability of the person to accurately perceive, evaluate, express and regulate emotions and feelings.

The five components of EQ are the following:

1. *Self-regulation*. This refers to the ability to calm down anxiety, control impulsiveness, and react appropriately to anger.
2. *Motivation*. This refers to the passion to work for reason that go beyond money or status
3. *Empathy*. This refers to the ability to respond to the unspoken feelings of others
4. *Self-awareness*. This refers to the awareness of one's own personality or individuality
5. *Social skills*. This refers to the proficiency to manage relationships and building networks.

MORE ON PHYSICAL ABILITY

Most writers of OB limit their discussion of physical ability traits like stamina, dexterity, and strength. They failed to mention other aspects that make individuals different from each other.

This writer feels that the following factors are important in determining the reasons for differences in individual behavior:

1. *Sense of sight*. People differ in what they actually see. For instance, some persons are color blind. Clearly, these persons will find it difficult to perform jobs that require the ability to distinguish colors.

2. *Sense of hearing*. People differ in their ability to hear. Some people may not be able to distinguish one tone from another. This alone makes them different from other people in terms of hearing ability. Those considered tone deaf would not be able to perform as singers, musicians, conductors, recording engineers and the like.

3. *Sense of taste*. A person's tongue may be sensitive to various tastes and this makes him or her different from another person who is less sensitive to taste. The degrees of taste sensitivity vary from person to person

4. *Sense of smell*. People have different degrees of sensitivity to smell. Those with excellent sense of smell would fit in jobs related to the manufacture of perfume, soap, food and some others.

5. *Sense of touch*. A person's sense of touch may differ in degree with another person's. As such, their behavior will differ when confronted with similar situations. For instance, when five persons are blindfolded, and they are requested to touch an object, some of them may be able to identify correctly the object and some will not.

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A carpenter needs a fine sense of touch when doing finishing jobs on wood in house construction. Obviously, some people will not qualify in such types of jobs.

Table 1
PERSONALITY FACTORS AND TRAITS

FACTORS	FACTORS
1. Emotional stability	
a. emotional stable person	-calm, confident, secure
b. emotionally unstable person	-nervous, depressed, insecure
2. Extraversion	
a. Extravert	-sociable, gregarious, assertive
b. Introvert	-reserved, timid, quiet
3. Openness to experience	
a. Open minded person	imaginative, cultured, curious, original, broad. minded, intelligent, artistically sensitive
b. Closed minded person	conventional, finds comfort in the familiar
4 Agreeableness	
a. Agreeable person	cooperative, warm, trusting
b. Disagreeable person	cold, disagreeable, antagonistic
5. Conscientiousness	
a Highly conscientious person	responsible, organized, dependable, persistent
b. Person with low score on conscientiousness	easily distracted, disorganized, unrealistic
6. Self-monitoring behavior	
a. High self-monitor	pragmatic, chameleon-like actor in social groups, often say what others want to hear
b. Low self-monitor	- avoid situations that require him/her to adapt to different outer images, is often inflexible
7. Risk taking and thrill seeking	
a. Risk taker	- willingness to take risks and pursue thrills
b. Play safe person	- not willing to take risks and pursue thrills
8. Optimism	
a. Optimist	- tendency to experience positive emotional states and to believe that positive outcome will be forthcoming from most activities
b. Pessimist	tendency to experience negative emotional states and to typically believe that negative outcomes will be forthcoming from most activities.

Summary

Relating with people will be less difficult if one is acquainted with individual differences, mental ability, and personality.

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Each person is different from all others and these differences are substantial rather than meaningless.

People differ in productivity, quality of work, reaction empowerment reaction to style of leadership need for contact with others, commitment to the organization, and level of self-esteem

Demographics, aptitude, ability, and personality are the factors that make people different from each other.

The sources of demographic diversity among people are gender, generational differences and age, and culture.

A person's ability consists of mental and physical.

Personality is determined by heredity and environment.

The components of EQ are self-regulation, motivation, empathy, self-awareness and social skills. Finally, people are different from each other in terms of their ability to see, hear, smell, taste, and touch.

Assessment

Answer the following questions in a separate sheet of paper. Submit to your teacher via google classroom email or messenger.

File name should be [Surname/Activity 2/Leadership in Organization]

ex. **Dela Cruz Activity 2 Leadership in Organization**

1. Why is the study of individual differences, mental ability, and personality an important activity?
2. What is meant by "individual differences"?
3. What are the consequences of having people with individual differences working together in an organization?
4. In what ways are people different from each other?
5. What are the sources of demographic diversity among people?
6. Are there differences between men and women which affect job performance?
7. What is meant by "aptitude"? by "ability"?
8. What comprises the overall ability of a person?
9. What is the Triarchic Theory of Intelligence?
10. What are the determinants of personality?

References

Human Behavior in Organization by Roberto Medina, Ph. D

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